

Asker Lane

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From Hassuk Kjarr

By
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Contents

Introduction; Hassuk kjarr	1
Asker Lane	2
Aerial photograph of Asker Lane	Illustn 2
Land at the time of the Enclosure	Illustn 2
Turnpike milestone no. 8	Illustn 3
Lums Dale & Hill	3
Bentley Brook Quarry	Illustn 3
Mr Wildgoose's Quarry	Illustn 4
Matlock	4
Boundaries and Boundary Stones	5
Sketch of the Seven Brethren	Illustn 5
Seven Brethren as shown on map	Illustn 5
Parish Boundaries	6
Possible Location of the Seven Brethren	Illustn 6
A Boundary Stone at Cardinshaw	Illustn 7
TCD Parish Boundary Stone	Illustn 7
Bailey's Tump	7
Plan of the Searchlight Unit	Illustn 7
The Geology	8
Number 13	8
Burdetts map of Derbyshire 1791	Illustn 8
Map of Housing Estate 2004	Illustn 9
Names of fields in Gratton's 1840 Tithe Map	Illustn 9

Introduction; Hassuc Kjarr

This is very much a draft, the result of some months' investigation and already the area of interest has grown a bit. It sets out to record in full what I have found is documented and it might serve as a starting point, perhaps for others. It is intended mainly to seek responses from those who know differently or better! Already the text has been altered in response to such feedback.

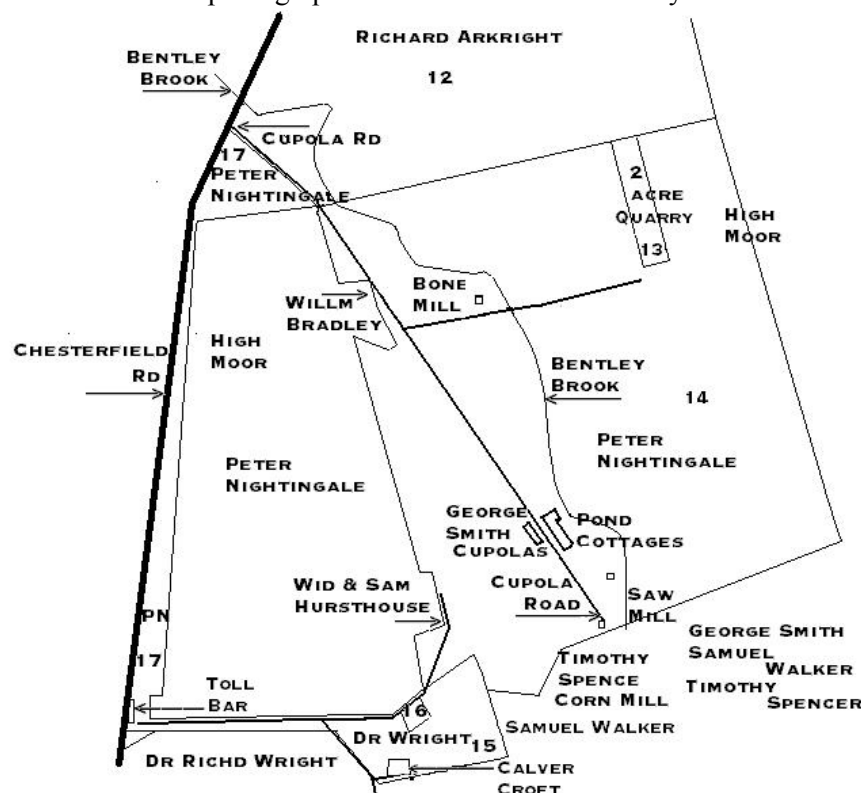
It has almost entirely involved the use of secondary sources. As necessary I rewrite parts and then reprint updated versions if they are requested but that does mean there will be variations and the only clue will be the print date. This is in fact the third edition with attention now given to the Roman period. Imperial measures are used where reporting people who would use such units.

I have already had much appreciated help from many sources including Lynn Willies, Stuart Band, Gladwyn Turbutt, Julie Bunting and Peter Naylor as well as the staff at Derbyshire Records Office and the Local Studies Library. My wife, Margaret, as throughout our married life, has given me re-assurance when I have ventured into print by has correcting the English usage for which I remain grateful..

George Wigglesworth
13, Lums Hill Rise
December 2006



Aerial photograph of Asker Lane taken in the year 2000



INFORMATION FROM THE SCHEDULE IN WHICH THE COMMISSIONERS DESCRIBE THEIR ACTIONS WHEN ENCLOSING THE COMMON LAND IN 1780

Land at the time of the Enclosure Act

Asker Lane

The useful features for placing the location on older maps are the Bentley Brook crossing of the Chesterfield turnpike and the 18th Mile Stone of early days. This turnpike was the road from Chesterfield to Matlock. Some authors associate this turnpike with a continuation to Ashbourne as milestones on early maps imply. In fact the Ashbourne-Wirksworth-Alfreton turnpike was authorised the year before this one. The milestones from Middleton to Ashbourne name Alfreton and are engraved, unlike the Chesterfield-Matlock ones. In 1772 some turnpikes were done away with, more in 1822 and the remainder in 1889. This one was wound up in 1880.

The 1791 map of Burdett only shows the Lumsdale cupola and names East Moor and Would (The Wold) as well as the milestone and Bentley Brook. Sanderson's "Map of Derbyshire" (1834) indicates a Toll Bar on the turnpike immediately NE of the junction with what we know as Asker Lane and three buildings at the bend of Asker Lane where it goes into Lums Dale. One of these might well be Asker Farm, the others old cottages, perhaps those now called "The Cottage" and "Yew Tree Cottage" which are outlined on Gratton's Tithe Map in 1848. A photograph dated 1893 features the Toll Bar cottage opposite the Duke of Wellington. It is believed to have been taken shortly before the demolition of the cottage and certainly was not mentioned by Bryan when he listed five toll bars in Matlock in 1903. Asker Lane was referred to as a "Private" road in the enclosure schedule of 1780. Gratton's larger scale map of 1848 names it as Horsecarlane Toll Bar and shows the buildings with more detail of shape and location.

The first edition of the 1" OS map (1840) names Asker Lane as Hasal Lane (it is very difficult to read especially the middle letter) and some milestones have been renumbered and placed differently, the nearest being the one that still exists opposite the golf clubhouse (8). This unelaborate stone matches two which remain on the Darley Dale branch. There is no engraved lettering so mileage and direction was probably painted onto the sides. They have trapezoid ends with four main, rectangular faces, the back 12" across, the sides, inclined to the road, 15" and the front 4", the stone standing 30" out of the ground and with a curved top. Some have been replaced or duplicated by triangular iron ones. There was an Act of Parliament requiring turnpikes to display milestones and these to relate to that particular stretch of road. A penalty (up to 40s) had to be instituted to deter the vandalising of these stones.



Turnpike milestone no. 8

One just north of Smedley Street (9) has now gone, probably when the road was widened and the eastern wall rebuilt. The original numbering is found on Cary's map of 1787, Burdett's map, 1791, Tuke's in 1798, in 1805 and on the one by Teesdale in 1829.

The earlier history suggests the name derives from *Hassuc Kjarr* where Hassuc is a firm tuft or clump of matted grass or sedge and Kjarr is the word carr, a boggy piece of ground, a combined name which could well be used for land in this area. The names Hasker, Haskar, Haskar Farme are found in documents such as Feet of Fines. In his will (10 Sept 1573) Wm Madder a lead burner (smelter) of Hasker bequeathed his "mansion house" to his wife Elizabeth and other things to his four sons. He is associated with a bole at Brown Edge thought to be in Ashover parish. The Turnpike documents use various names but most often Haskar. The many lanes, pathways and tracks contouring the hillside from Tansley to Darley Dale remain enigmatic. Paved in part, they may be local and/or long distance routes.

One concludes therefore that "Asker" is derived from an ancient name which could be 500 years old. Asker Lane seems to have developed from a private road, such as one to the farm, mainly over the last 200 years.



Bentley Brook Quarry

Lums Dale & Hill

Searches have shown Lumm to be used somewhere in the country as early as 1290 and 1309. It seems to be written in several ways, as Lums, Lumbs or Lummes. Locally the name "Lum" is used to identify a hill although it is far more often used of the dale. Lumshill Quarry is at the northerly end of the Lumsdale/Lumshill Quarry complex, ¼ mile east of Bentley Bridge, and, unnamed, is a part of the Enclosure Act distribution in 1780. In 1840 it was still the Parish Quarry. Lumsdale Quarry (a source of grindstones) is on the edition of the OS map dated 1876 while Lumshill Quarry is named on the OS 25000 map of 1983. However the derivation of "Lums" is not yet finally established.

The OED gives various meanings of which lumb for a "well for the collection of water in a mine" or "the handle of an oar" seem unlikely. It might more probably be a man's name, be used for a deep pool in a river (possibly a mill pond?) or a word for chimney. It is also used to depict a wooded valley or a small wood. Peter Naylor writes that he believes that Lumsdale is an old British name used for a close sided valley, dark as a result. He has identified it in Lumb Brook and two Lumb Lanes nearby, at Blackbrook Derbyshire as well as Lumbertubs Pass in Cumbria. There are references to Lumbs Mill in Matlock in Court of Chancery papers in 1700 and in the Enclosure Act of 1780 but without locating it more precisely. In the Turnpike minutes Lumbs Mill is mentioned when the road was diverted in 1822, going down Lumsdale between Bentley Bridge and Matlock. The submitted map suggests the mill was in the Lumsdale. (This diversion was seemingly not implemented or if so only for a limited period.) Lumbs Mill is used as the name of Common Land and Waste Grounds possibly to the northeast of the mills in Lumsdale. It is, however, also used to pertain to "buildings, weirs, goyts and appurtenances". This usage could imply one mill with more than one pool.

Corn mills are located at three places on Bentley Brook. One reference is to an upper and lower mill. One mill could be at Hunts Bridge in Matlock Green. This is out of the close valley of Lumsdale as it is now known and maybe referred to in one document as the lower mill and perhaps one referred to in 1254. In Lumsdale both the "Paint Mill" and the "Grinding Mill" are thought to have been corn mills. Mr Lumb's mill might, interestingly, be imagined to be one of these three. A search of registers has yielded no reference to persons using the surname Lum[b] locally although it is common both as a surname and place name in the West Riding. In 1840 on the OS map the only name of a mill is that given to "Whites", a family name known from earlier.

If Lum derives from an actual chimney such would of course have been an obvious feature in a narrow valley like this, with tracks above. A prominent chimney still stands. The industrial development is a feature for which the valley is notable. Its earlier developments relied on water power, not solid fuel, although a flue was also used to condense the fumes from lead smelting which is documented for three locations in Lumsdale and flues are to be found in this valley. Farey refers to a former lead cupola in 1811. In 1780 the road was called "Cupola Road" serving cupolas operated by George Smith and a tentative date for one lead works is placed in the 17th century. The locations of two mills are today associated with previous lead production, "The Bone Mill" and "The Pond Cottages". However "lum" meaning chimney is mainly used in the northernmost parts of England and in Scotland and seems associated with the Saxon word "*leom*" for light, the open chimney in the roof being an important, even the only, source of daylight at one time in houses of the poor.

Glover in 1829 refers to the Cascades and Waterfall in Lumsdale. Lumsdale and Lums Plantation are used on the 1848 map. The first edition of the 1" OS map surveyed in the late 1830s named Lums Dale. The name 'Lumsdale' therefore has not yet been found before the nineteenth century and can now conveniently be used of the distinctive, steep walled valley down to its confluence with Tansley Brook.

Provisionally I think most probably the name Lums derives from pools; if from a Mr Lumb there is never an apostrophe or the local use of the surname Lumb. It could describe the steep sided, wooded valley but chimneys as the source of the name remain only a slight possibility. The mystery seems to remain. One imagines Lums Hill and the quarry would, either way, have followed the naming of Lums Dale.



Mr Wildgoose's Quarry, Lumsdale

Matlock

In Domesday and other documents reference is made to Meslach and Mestesforde (variously spelt) without clearly defining the areas so named. The former may be Matlock Town and Matlock Green, the south of Bentley Brook where it joins the Derwent, where the church and mill are located. The latter, a crossing of the river, might be near where Matlock Bridge is now which is first written as "pontem de Matelock" in about 1250.. The name Matlock is used and seems to have assimilated both areas. Matlac and Matloc were spellings used in about 1200 but the cognacy of all the words used is problematical. The name Mettesford has been revived to be used as a street name on the Hurst Farm Estate.

Matlock was a manor owned by William the Conqueror, presumably succeeding King Edward. It was part of Henry de Ferrer's estate in the county comprising as many as 150 manors. A "plumbariae" (lead hearth) is recorded at Matlock Bridge and would have been a bole on one of the hills. Reference to it as "partly waste" may be associated with the punitive actions of William, who made stern reprisals in the county, or to failed agricultural ventures in the harsh uplands. It would have had outlying farming settlements, berewicks. King John granted it to William de Ferrers, Earl of Derby. When he rebelled these were confiscated and granted to Edmund "Crouchback", Duke of Lancaster, who lived in the second half of the 13th century.



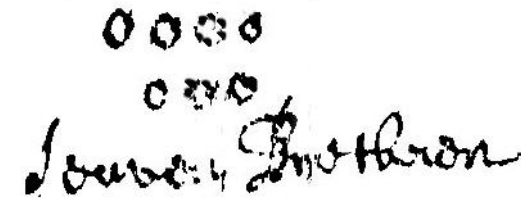
Hayman Rooke's sketch of the Seven Brethren

The Boundaries and Boundary Stones

The parish boundary was initially associated with the Lordship and the Manor thereof. The ecclesiastical parish may have coincided with this in early days and beating the bounds was associated with the church and most early boundary markers were to show these bounds. Most early references are to these boundaries therefore. We often get information from the adjoining parish which in this limited case is Ashover and Matlock. Tansley was in Crich Parish and had a Lordship of Tansley. It is civil parishes which are now shown on O.S. maps.

The earliest reference I know is the sketch map drawn of the perambulation of the bounds in 1687 by 52 inhabitants of Ashover. It names Cardinshawhead Stoop and the Seven Brethren as well as Matlock and Tansley Parish although the latter did not really exist. Cardinshaw Stoop existed (map reference 321 618) near Wayside Farm and was then shown to be on Wigleys enclosure. (Cardinshaw Sitch must have run down "Fardale" as it was called in 1840. Sitch, sick and syke are used locally to mean stream). Another stone is labelled 1753 AP & MP (325 620). It still exists and is carved on one side "MP" (Matlock Parish) and on another "1753".

A sketch of Seven Brethren is found in Hayman Rooke's Derbyshire Sketch Book from the last half of the 18th century. His text, when deciphered, seems to say: *-The remains of a Druid Circle at the SE end of Matlock Moor, called the Seven Brideron Stones. They appear to have been erect, the hight of No (1) 7 feet, diameter of the circle 25 feet, several small Barrows are scattered about on this circumference about 40 feet, the present hight in the 2 feet.*



Seven Brethren as shown on a 1687 sketch map

He uses the word 'Brideron'. The Old English letter written as 'ð', called 'eth', would make this the 'th' sound as in brethren as opposed to the 'þ' called 'thorn' and sounded as 'th' in thorn. (Simeon Potter [1950] tells us that "for mechanical reasons Elizabethans printed 'the' as 'ye'". It is this usage which explains 'The Olde English Tea Shoppe' being wrongly rendered 'Ye olde...') So we speculate 'brideron' is a local pronunciation of 'brethren', cf. the German 'brüder'.

PJ Naylor in "A History of the Matlocks", 2003 writes

It is recorded that another stone age edifice existed on Matlock Moor called the Seven Brideron, cleared in the 19th century, possibly by quarrymen for the stone. It was recorded in October 1764 as being a seven-stone circle, but another observer recorded it as a nine-stone circle with some stones standing higher than a tall man on a diameter of 7.5m. There is no trace of this circle today; it stood a few hundred metres north of Palethorpe Farm.

Morgan and Morgan write in (p 88 "Rock around the Peak", Wilmslow 2001) *"The most famous of these lost circles, which had disappeared by the 19th century, is the Seven Brideron. The site was described by Rooke on a visit in 1754 as being located at the South Eastern end of Matlock Moor However in recent years a further account by Samuel Pegg [a contemporary of Rooke] has come to light, suggesting that the circle was actually located at the North-eastern corner of Matlock Moor, consisted of nine stones rather than seven and was called the Seven Brethren rather than Brideron. The debate has now ended as a Boundary Award Map dating to 1779 places the circle around GR SK310 635, where Pegg said it was."*

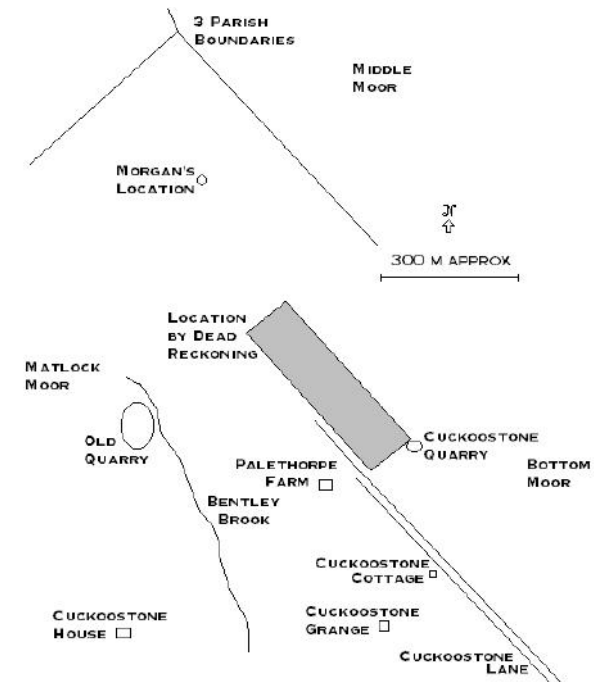
There are two matters to be resolved: where and how many were the "Brethren"? It is interesting that on the 1687 map of the perambulation of Ashover Parish it is called Seven Brethren and depicted as four circles over three as shown by Rooke and justifying 7 rather than 9 stones in the circle. The notebook of Titus Wheatcroft, Parish Clerk of Ashover, contains the following notes made in 1722 and addressed to his successors:

I now come to show you by marks how large the parish is in its outermost bounds; which marks are usually viewed by the inhabitants on the day called Holy Thursday [Ascension Day, Ed.]. On the Sunday before, notice is given in the church that the boundaries will be viewed on Thursday next, prayers usually beginning on the same morning at seven o'clock, where they meet, some come on horseback and others on foot to view these marks following. This is called the yearly perambulation, and is observed in Rogation week." He then lists the marks referring to "11. Seven Brethren".

The editor of Derbyshire Archaeological Journal, 1892, gives his opinion, when they republished his account, namely, "Probably as many trees, or perhaps stones (?of some pre-historic circle)." Nonetheless nine standing stones would make a better closed circle than the seven Rooke drew.

The only way to establish the location of The Seven Brethren with any confidence is by dead reckoning using Nuttall's map. One known point on it is the Harland stone (338 598) which was still to be found where the Ryber Road (a road no longer to be found at this point) met the ancient road from Matlock via Tansley to Mansfield. Other existing boundary markers are at the Crowder Stone (350 595) and one of the two at Cardinshaw (32 61) all being also shown on Jno. Nuttall's map of 1777. This could be from the same dispute as the one identified by the Morgans referred to above (disputes did last). The map was for a boundary dispute between Ashover and Tansley. (The Holymoorside History Society quite wrongly moved the Harland Stone from the place it had been for more than 250 years to a place of their choosing at Five Lane Ends.)

By this means I place the Seven Brethren within a rectangle about ½ km x ¼ km, one corner being 700m north of Cuckoostone House (at 310 631) the opposite one at Cuckoostone Quarry NE of Cuckoostone Lane. (at 315 629), This is within 300m of the map reference the Morgans give. It must be remarked that if boundaries used prominent landmarks then three parishes met 300m NNW of there, supposing the boundaries still follow the same line as the last half of the 18th century. The presence of the quarry so near the location I give fits an explanation of their possible disappearance by quarrying about which Peter Naylor wrote. Whether it is in the NE or SE of Matlock Moor I suppose depends on how they delineated the featureless Matlock Moor of those times. On more recent maps Bottom Moor and Middle Moor appear to join Matlock Moor on the northeast border and if these are regarded as separate then the Seven Brethren are in the NE corner, in which case Rooke could be right. It must be remembered this land was not yet enclosed and the land between Matlock Moor and the Chesterfield turnpike is not named.



Possible Location of the Seven Brethren

Parish Boundaries

The Parish boundary at the time of the Enclosure Act and Gratton's Tithe map was on the further north east side of Lumsdale. The ecclesiastical parish of Matlock was reduced by transferring land to the Chapelry at Tansley through an Order in Council by Queen Victoria on 18th May 1865 (the date is after the tithe map was drawn). This essentially moved the boundary to the middle of the Chesterfield - Matlock turnpike from the boundary post on Matlock Moor to just beyond Bentley Bridge and then down Lumsdale (road). It was drawn across the fields to include Asker Farm in Tansley and down Bull Lane to Hurst Farm which remained in Matlock. It dropped from there into Lumsdale and on to Matlock Cliff and beyond. The above "Order in Council" is very precise, using named field boundaries and five boundary stones (engraved "TCD 1864", nos 1 to 5. The initials may be of Tansley Chapelry Derbyshire). Such a boundary stone on the left as Bull Lane ends is almost buried but can be visualised in its entirety from one seen on the right as you approach Hearthstone Farm. No others have yet been located and nos. 1 and 2 may well have disappeared when houses and Highfields School were built.



A Boundary Stone
at Cardinshaw Head

The boundaries of ecclesiastical parishes are less easily determined these days without access to records at the Church Commissioners. The boundary has been changed since then as All Saints was established in the late 19th century and recently when Asker Farm and the new houses were identified with Matlock rather than Tansley.



TCD (Tansley) Parish
Boundary Stone at
Hearthstone Farm

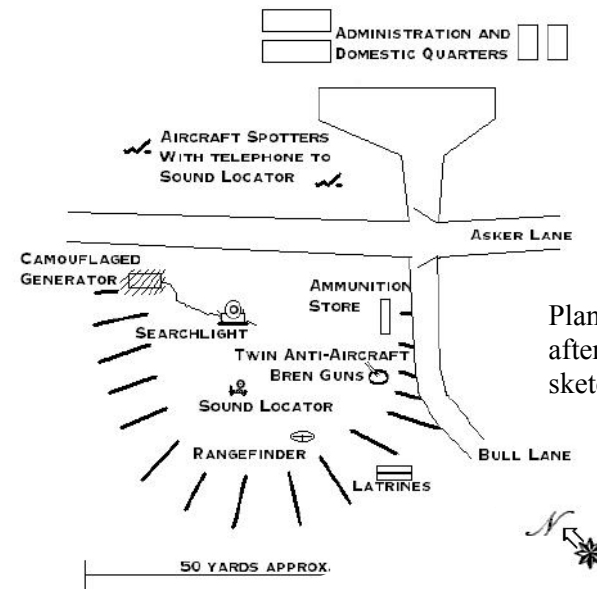
Bailey's Tump

This is on "Pingle" NW of the junction of Bull Lane and Asker Lane. The memories of Peter Attwater are reflected in Peter Naylor's "A History of the Matlocks".

"The regular Army manned an anti-aircraft gun located on Bailey's Tump (this was a spoil heap from mining the aqueduct [i.e. water pipe] for the water main from the Derwent Dams to the south) off Asker Lane established in 1939 and compromised

- *Four huts:- the messing facilities and barracks with separate latrines*
- *Three aircraft spotters with a field telephone to the sound locator*
- *A mobile sound locator*
- *Searchlight, also mobile, which was connected by cables to a petrol generator*
- *A petrol generator*
- *Twin anti-aircraft "Bren" guns*
- *Range finder*
- *Ammunition store (some distance from the above)*
- *Concrete bunker for protection from attack*

Most of the above were protected by sand bags, especially the ammunition store. The establishment had a crew of 10 from which it could be assumed that a total of 30 soldiers were needed. The installation did engage the enemy, the last time was when a lone fighter-bomber flew over in February 1945 and let off a burst of machine-gun fire. This was the eighth engagement. At other times when the searchlight located aircraft, a message was sent to other similar establishments round Manchester and Sheffield. The establishment was in continuous use from mid-1940 to late 1944.



Plan of the Searchlight Unit
after Peter F Attwater's
sketch map

The Matlock Mercury, Nov 2004 writes that an aircraft was hit by anti-aircraft fire from the unit and crashed in Great Longstone.

It is probably incorrect to refer to “a battery” as any guns would only be light guns (such as the Brens mentioned) to deter *strafing* of the prominent searchlight, batteries of heavier guns, sited elsewhere, being used to attack incoming planes. Rather this would be a searchlight unit.

The Geology

The immediate area is on a low-permeability drift material overlying major and minor aquifers based in potentially fractured gritstone rock. The geological map for Matlock shows 13 Lums Hill Rise to be on a drift of Boulder Clay over Ashover Grit. East Moor, which starts north of Chatsworth, extends to this region and south to Lea, just including some of the Asker Lane housing development. It is the geological history of East Moor which determines the landform of this area. The area around here is drained by four brooks starting from a subterranean reservoir in the Namurian Series: Lea Brook to the South, Sydnop Brook down to Two Dales, the River Amber through Ashover and Bentley Brook through Lumsdale. Each cuts through the same Pleistocene series with the same steep slopes and gradual shelves.

Bentley Brook emerges on Cuckoostone Moor at the edge of the moorland plateau which is slightly inclined towards the South. This hanging valley falls rapidly over the Chatsworth Grit (a “Middle Grit of the Marsdenian Stage”) in the clough between Cuckoostone House and the Grange (as does the steep incline of the road at the top of the Golf Course). It is this sandstone which has been quarried at the top of Cuckoostone Dale, and in Bentley Brook and Lumsdale Quarries. The layer is over 30m thick and well exposed in Lumshill Quarry. Cuckoostone Dale finally has a somewhat slower, more meandering, stream bed across the golf course and this is where it crosses the rapidly weathered shale belt between the grits. It is on this zone that the Asker Lane development is found.

It is from this area that much of North Matlock’s water was derived. The “Wold’s spring” with its man made reservoir was an early and main source of supply. A plan to “embank” Bentley Brook was contemplated at the end of the 19th century when a water diviner had also been used. Two bore holes and water intercepted by trenches from springs now also contribute to Matlock’s supply from this level of geological stratum which also serves communities as dispersed as Chatsworth and Dethick.

The next layer up to 60m thick is also a Middle Grit, the Ashover Grit of Lumsdale where the course of the brook is influenced by its redirection by man, but the deep, rocky clough is very striking. The exposed rock can be followed as the Broad Stone (Wishingstone), the steep land above Hurst Farm Estate, the rocky edge between Cavendish Road and Smedley Street, especially where it was quarried, and on towards Darley hillside. Below this is a final belt of weathered shale above the limestone (here of the grey Cawdor series, a layer 60m thick) which starts at Matlock Green to extend into the Limestone Peak.

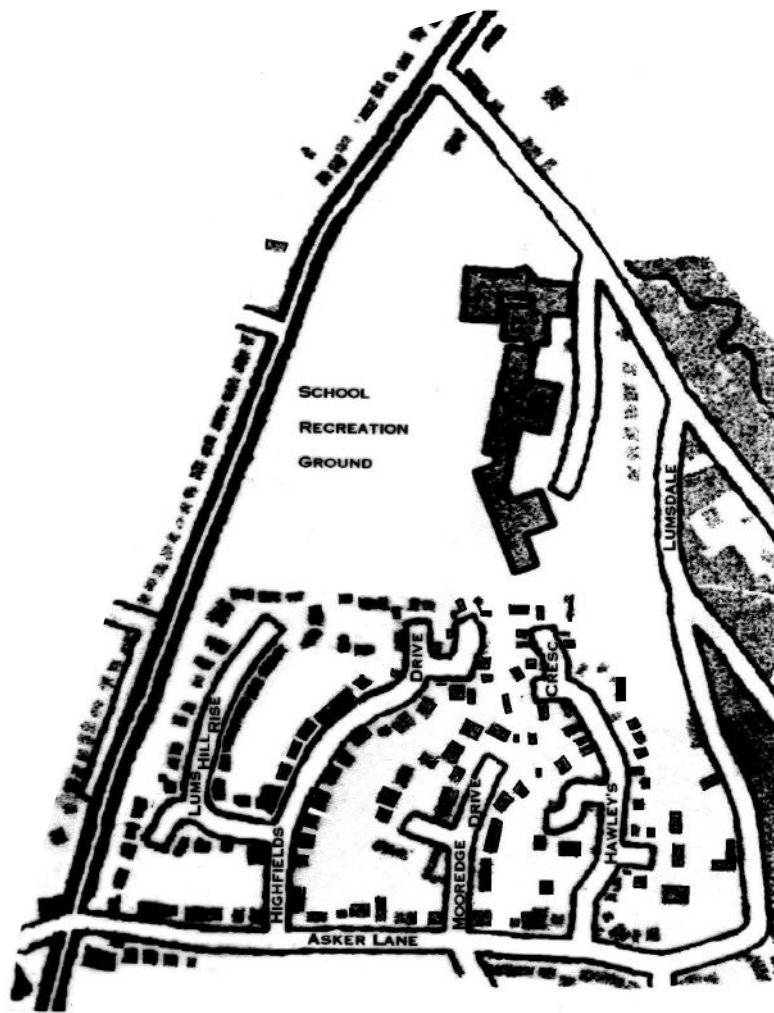
Number 13

13, Lums Hill Rise is built in “Long Close”, a field shown on Joseph Gratton’s map of 1848 and referred to when the major water main was built from the upper Derwent Valley to the cities to the south..

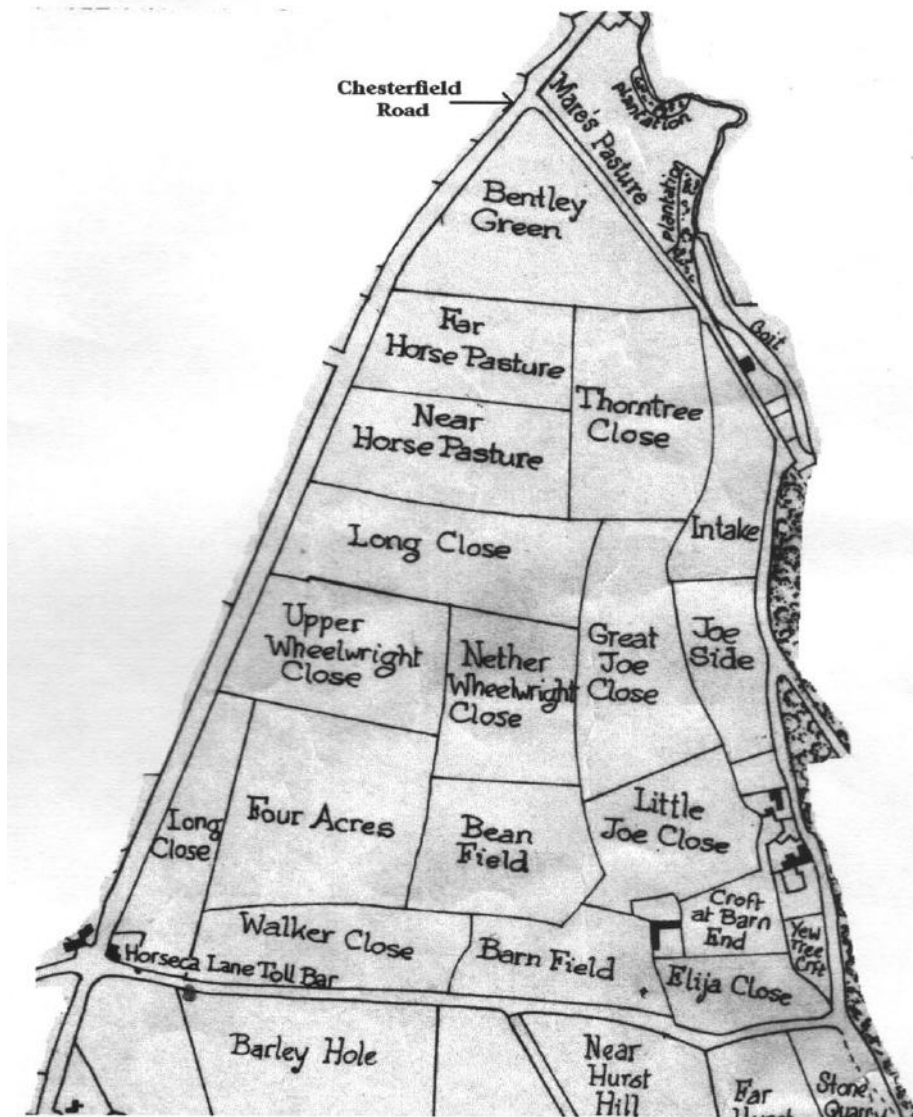
It is about 100 metres from Asker Lane and 25 metres from Chesterfield Road at about 670 feet (206 metres) above sea level. Its map reference is SK 4307 3609.



Burdett's map of Derbyshire 1791



Map of Housing Estate 2004



Names of fields in Gratton's 1840 Tithe Map